standing committee of chief ministers of the affected states, also working under the home minister, has been formed to address political, security and socioeconomic development issues. At the executive level, there are various organizations that have been set up to tackle the menace. Integrated action plans covering sixty of these districts are being launched, but the principle of 'effective governance before development' would be sacrosanct before these plans are put into action.

The army has been carefully monitoring the developments and playing an advisory role to the government. It is also providing training assistance to the police and the paramilitary forces in various states on their request. We helped to set up the first counterinsurgency school at Kanker in Chattisgarh. I have been clear from the beginning that the army should not get embroiled in this problem as that would play into the hands of inimical forces, and detract us from our primary task of defence of our nation. I maintained this stance as the chief as it was not in our national interest. I am happy to see the policy has remained unchanged since then.

As army chief, my views on the repealing of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA) 1958 created a lot of ripples. Some people have termed it as a 'draconian law' that gives unbridled powers to the armed forces while they conduct operations against insurgents or terrorists. I believe that the armed forces are the instrument of last resort for a nation. Therefore, they must be given the responsibility of restoring law and order in a specific area only when all other means have failed. When such a situation arises, it becomes mandatory for the state to ensure that the armed forces are provided the necessary moral, material and legal support and wherewithal to overcome the challenge. When asked by the media, my categoric reply was that I would not like my soldiers to fight with one hand tied behind their back, or to be dragged to the courts on flimsy charges. While we shall take all steps to prevent human rights violations and punish those guilty of an offence, we would not